

Disenfranchised Grief and Meaning Reconstruction in the Wake of Animal Loss

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Abstract

The death of a beloved animal can lead to profound grief, akin to the loss of a human loved one. Yet, it is often minimized by societal norms, resulting in disenfranchised grief for many pet guardians and animal caregivers. This qualitative phenomenological study, grounded in meaning reconstruction theory, explored the emotional and mental health impacts of such grief, support interventions perceived as most helpful, and the validation needs of grieving individuals. Semi-structured interviews with 31 animal caregivers underwent thematic analysis, revealing three central themes: The Psychological Toll of Disenfranchised Grief, highlighting emotional burden and isolation; Meaning-Making and Continued Bonds After Loss, describing remembrance, transformation, and connection; and The Restorative Role of Social Recognition, emphasizing healing through validation. Findings underscore the importance of social context, continued bonds, and meaning-making, with implications for psychologists, counselors, educators, and organizations to acknowledge and validate grief that is not culturally or professionally recognized.

Keywords

disenfranchised grief, animal loss, bereavement, support, meaning making, pet loss

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The death of an animal can result in profound grief that parallels the emotional impact of losing a human companion (Bowen et al., 2021; Packman et al., 2014). For some, animals may be viewed as replaceable, which can lead to disenfranchised grief for the animal caregiver. With 66% of households in the United States having pets (American Pet Products Association, 2024) and a workforce of over 750,000 animal care and service professionals, including animal trainers and caregivers (U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2024), it is crucial to acknowledge the impact of disenfranchised grief associated with the death of an animal and explore supports to help caregivers and pet guardians cope with their loss.

Grief is a universal experience. Zhumatii (2022) and Engler-Gross et al. (2020) wrote that the grief experience is multidimensional, affecting every aspect of a person, including psychological, biological, emotional, social, and spiritual. Moreira et al. (2023) wrote that grief is complex, most often associated with the death of a loved one, but grief can be a result of any loss that a person experiences. Sadness and longing are common reactions, and the person experiencing the loss yearns for what is no longer present. Grief can be both mentally and physically painful and can be responded to in adaptive and maladaptive ways. When a person experiences the death of a loved one, there are certain beneficial societal norms such as offering condolences, sending sympathy cards, or attending funerals that typically guide the response from others.

Disenfranchised grief is defined as when the grief that a person experiences “is not openly acknowledged, socially validated, or publicly observed” (Doka, 2002, p. 5). Doka (2002) introduced the concept of disenfranchised grief, which is expanded upon in the same volume by Meyers (2002) in relation to animal loss. The person grieving may not feel they are allowed to mourn their loss because the loss they have experienced is considered trivial compared to the loss of a loved human and does not fit with societal expectations. Doka (2002) listed five categories of disenfranchised grief. These categories are when the relationship is not recognized, the loss is not acknowledged, the griever is excluded, the circumstances of death, and the ways individuals grieve.

Mouton (2024) wrote that contributing influences to experiencing disenfranchised grief can include perinatal deaths, abortions, extra-marital relationship deaths, ex-spouse deaths, incarcerated person's death, deaths by suicide, and deaths by drug overdose, as these are deaths that society may refuse to acknowledge as significant. Other studies on disenfranchised grief include caregivers of people with dementia (Testoni et al., 2023), educators grieving student loss (Shalev et al., 2024), elementary school-aged children grieving when relationships with friends, support staff, and teachers change or end (Protivnak et al., 2020), and the grief associated with the death of a friend (Liu et al., 2019).

Disenfranchised grief extends beyond human loss. Packman et al. (2014) conducted a mixed-methods study with 200 participants from the United States and 35 participants from Canada who had gone through the death of a pet. Their findings showed that the participants in both countries experienced disenfranchised grief with a lack of acknowledgment and support from others, dismissal of the intensity of their loss, and minimization of the human-pet relationship.

[Marton et al. \(2020\)](#) studied 128 animal care workers regarding the death of an animal in their care. Their findings showed that the workers reported a lack of empathy from their personal social networks regarding the difficulties of their loss. The workers also reported that their organization did not adequately support or acknowledge their loss. This lack of empathy, support, and acknowledgment resulted in disenfranchised grief for the animal care workers. [Marton et al. \(2020\)](#) reported that depression is prevalent in the animal-training and veterinary communities, with empirical research showing that animal control workers (public service professionals responsible for protecting animal welfare and managing community safety) in the United States had a suicide rate 3.5 times higher than the general worker population. In the United Kingdom, veterinary surgeons were 5.5 times more likely to experience suicidal ideation than the general population.

[Macauley and Chur-Hansen's \(2022\)](#) and [Rodriguez et al.'s \(2020\)](#) studies reported that animals offer humans companionship, comfort, support, attachment, and affection in a domestic capacity. Animals may serve as social facilitators, creating a welcoming opening for others to interact and engage. [Merkouri et al. \(2022\)](#) reported that animals may also provide affection and belonging and give their human caregivers a purpose. [Bowen et al. \(2021\)](#) conducted a study with 501 participants to determine if dogs provided social support during a crisis, such as the COVID-19 pandemic. Their findings showed that most respondents reported that their dogs were a source of comfort and support and were viewed as confidants, similar to how they viewed their friends and family. For some individuals, emotional bonds with animals were as strong as, or even stronger than, those experienced with other people.

In addition to subjective reports of emotional closeness, empirical research has demonstrated tangible psychological and physiological benefits associated with animal companionship and service dogs, particularly among trauma-affected populations. Recent research has highlighted the therapeutic benefits of human-animal relationships, particularly in contexts of trauma and prolonged grief. [Pratt et al. \(2023\)](#) found that partners of military veterans described the family pet dog as a source of emotional security, structure, and nonjudgmental companionship, all of which supported household well-being. Similarly, [van Houtert et al. \(2022\)](#) reported that veterans and first responders partnered with trained service dogs experienced reduced post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) symptoms, improved emotional regulation, and better sleep. [Lessard et al. \(2020\)](#) corroborated these findings with actigraphy-based evidence, showing measurable improvements in both sleep quality and physical activity after service dog placement. Together, these studies emphasize that animal-assisted support offers not only emotional benefits but also tangible improvements in psychological and physiological functioning.

Theoretical Framework

Dr. Robert A. Neimeyer developed the meaning reconstruction framework for grief in 2001. Neimeyer's Meaning Reconstruction theory posits that grieving involves reconstructing a world of meaning that has been challenged by loss. Central to this

process are sense-making, benefit-finding, and the maintenance of continued bonds with the deceased. This framework is particularly well-suited for exploring grief that lacks social acknowledgment, as it emphasizes the bereaved person's internal narrative and the psychological work involved in adapting to loss. This study applies meaning reconstruction to examine how individuals process the death of a beloved animal in the absence of societal recognition, highlighting their efforts to reclaim meaning, identity, and emotional integration (Neimeyer, 2016, 2020).

Method

For some people, relationships with animals are just as meaningful and comparable to human relationships (Bowen et al., 2021; Packman et al., 2014). For the group of people who place a high value on their human-animal relationship, the death of a beloved animal can result in profound mourning and grief that parallels the death of a person. Individuals who do not place the same high value on human-animal relationships may not recognize the death of an animal as significant and, therefore, not acknowledge or recognize the loss, leading to disenfranchised grief for the person experiencing the loss of the animal.

A qualitative phenomenological approach was chosen for this study as it explores data from a person's individual account of their experiences. Qualitative research is particularly well-suited for exploring complex emotional and cognitive processes such as grief. As Busetto et al. (2020) noted, qualitative methods offer depth, contextual sensitivity, and flexibility, enabling researchers to capture nuanced, lived experiences and generate insight that may not be accessible through quantitative approaches. Cena et al. (2024) reflected that qualitative approaches are especially valuable for exploring deeply personal experiences and are guided by rigorously defined quality criteria tailored to specific methodologies.

Participants

Participants for this study were selected through purposive sampling. Campbell et al. (2020) wrote that purposive sampling involves selecting participants who are most likely to provide relevant and insightful information, maximizing the use of limited research resources. These intentionally selected individuals were likely to offer distinct and important viewpoints on the issues that were being explored, making their inclusion in the sample crucial. Participants were recruited using social media sites Facebook, Instagram, and TikTok. To allow for adequate representation of the experience of the phenomenon of disenfranchised grief due to the death of an animal, 31 participants who met the inclusion criteria were chosen to participate in the study. Inclusion criteria included that all participants must be or have been animal caregivers. All participants must have been in the occupation of a professional animal caregiver or must have had an animal as an at-home companion. All participants must have experienced the death of an animal in their care. All participants must have been, at minimum, 18 years old, of any gender and ethnicity, and speak and write English. All participants could reside

nationally or internationally. Exclusion criteria included individuals with no experience as an animal caregiver or companion animal owner, no experience with the death of an animal in their care, individuals under 18 years old, and individuals who did not speak or write English.

Instrumentation

This qualitative phenomenological study's primary data collection instrument was an in-depth, semi-structured interview comprised of 10 open-ended questions. Open-ended questions were purposely chosen to encourage participants to elaborate, reflect, and share their lived experiences in their own words, thus allowing for detailed and nuanced data that would align with the phenomenological approach. The questions were intentionally developed to gather information related to the presented research questions and to capture the participants' lived experiences of disenfranchised grief due to the death of an animal. The questions were designed to explore grief's emotional, social, and personal dimensions and the factors that may contribute to or hinder the participant's grieving process. The goal was to create questions that would address the research objectives while also being sensitive to the participants' grief experiences. Ethical and confidentiality considerations were also integrated to ensure that participants felt safe and supported during the interview process. There were 10 interview questions formulated for this study after researching and reviewing studies on pet bereavement, pet attachment, and disenfranchised grief (Cromer & Barlow, 2013; Hunt & Padilla, 2006; St Clair, 2013; Uccheddu et al., 2019). Each of these studies included questionnaires using Likert scales to collect data on the topics. Due to the qualitative nature of this study, a Likert scale questionnaire was not appropriate. However, information gathered from those questionnaires informed and shaped the creation of this study's 10 in-depth, semi-structured, open-ended questions.

The topics of the 10 questions included the personal significance of the animal for the participant, the emotional impact of the loss, whether there was a lack of social recognition of the grief, and how participants navigated or made sense of their experience. Demographic questions also delineated age range, gender, ethnicity, and the location in which the participant resides. These details provided more context and identified potential variations in the grief experience across different groups. To ensure validity, all participants were asked the same interview questions to ensure consistency, allow for comparability of responses, and help identify common themes. Participants were permitted to review transcriptions to confirm the accuracy of their statements. The development of the interview protocol was informed by a review of relevant literature on disenfranchised grief, attachment theory, animal loss, and existing qualitative studies on grief and loss.

Online interviews were recorded with the participant's permission using Google Meet. Recordings of meetings were stored in the Google Meet program and encrypted to prevent unauthorized access. Participants' responses were transcribed using Google Meet. Recordings were compared to transcriptions to ensure accuracy. Participants were permitted to review transcriptions to confirm the accuracy of their statements.

Interviews were conducted in a private space to ensure privacy and confidentiality. The anticipated length of time to complete the interview was estimated to be 30–60 min.

Data Analysis

Interview transcriptions were read through in their entirety to prepare and organize the data. Reading through all of the data provided an opportunity to reflect on the overall meaning and ideas of the answers. There was no editing of colloquialisms or filler words to maintain the authenticity of the participants' responses. Recordings were compared to transcriptions to ensure accuracy. The qualitative computer software program ATLAS.ti 25 was used for the coding process, analysis of transcripts, and to assist with identifying themes. The data representation included a detailed discussion of several interconnecting themes to convey the analysis's findings. The meanings and themes found from the collected data were explored, and the data were organized to identify what emerged from the shared phenomenon of disenfranchised grief associated with the death of an animal.

Results

Analysis of the 31 participant interviews revealed three central themes that illuminate the lived experience of disenfranchised grief after the loss of an animal. These were: The Psychological Toll of Disenfranchised Grief, Meaning-Making and Continued Bonds After Loss, and The Restorative Role of Social Recognition. Each theme is described in detail below, supported by direct participant quotations that illustrate the emotional, cognitive, and relational dimensions of this form of grief.

The Psychological Toll of Disenfranchised Grief

Participants described the emotional weight of grieving an animal in a society that often denies or minimizes that grief. Because the death of a non-human companion is frequently not recognized as a legitimate loss, many participants felt pressure to hide their pain or justify the depth of their emotions. As P023 explained, "When a loved one dies, you get time off work. When a pet dies, you're expected to stuff down your feelings and act like nothing is wrong."

This lack of recognition led to internalized shame, self-doubt, and emotional suppression. For some, the absence of acknowledgment was experienced as a secondary wound, complicating the grieving process. P005 reflected, "When my grief was minimized, it made me self-grieve more, not really talk about the losses. I internalize it all."

Participants also shared how the mismatch between their emotional experience and others' expectations led to isolation. Many described grieving privately or withdrawing from social situations to avoid judgment. P025 shared, "I started waking up with chest pain and panic attacks. It wasn't until my doctor asked if I'd experienced loss that I realized I had been suppressing so much."

Minimizing reactions, often in the form of well-intentioned but hurtful remarks like “It was just a pet” or “You can always get another”, were common. These comments reinforced a societal hierarchy of grief in which animal loss is viewed as inherently less significant. Participants reported feeling embarrassed, reluctant to share, or uncertain whether their grief was valid.

These external messages also shaped internal responses. Many participants admitted to censoring their grief, downplaying their emotions, or avoiding conversations to appear socially appropriate. This aligns with broader cultural grief norms that discourage visible mourning for animals. As a result, participants described emotional numbness, prolonged sadness, anxiety, depression, compassion fatigue, and symptoms consistent with trauma.

This toll was especially pronounced for those in animal care professions, who described layered grief related to personal loss, occupational exposure to death, and lack of institutional support. Several reported burnout and emotional exhaustion when their grief went unacknowledged within their professional environments. In some cases, even well-meaning efforts to provide support or offer coping strategies left participants feeling unseen. The absence of open acknowledgment disrupted the ability to make sense of the loss and compounded emotional strain. Overall, participants emphasized that their grief was compounded when unacknowledged by others. When others failed to recognize their pain, the grief became more isolating, emotionally disruptive, and difficult to resolve.

Meaning-Making and Continued Bonds after Loss

Despite the lack of social validation, many participants described deeply personal and symbolic processes that supported their grieving. These included reflective rituals, storytelling, gratitude practices, and the preservation of meaningful objects, all of which allowed for continued bonds and emotional integration. As P007 shared, “I have urns, footprint tiles, leashes. I keep them all. I know it sounds like a mortuary, but it’s part of my healing.”

Participants often emphasized that the loss represented more than the absence of the animal; it was the severing of a stabilizing and deeply relational presence. The animals were sources of companionship, emotional regulation, identity, and purpose. P022 illustrated this connection through ritualized remembrance: “She loved eating roses, so I picked a bunch and threw them in the ocean after she died.”

Many also described shifts in values, self-understanding, or personal growth as part of their grieving journey. The pain of loss often coexisted with gratitude. P027 reflected, “The lessons they’ve taught me are many and great. I am so grateful for them. What a special life I feel like I’ve lived because of them.” These meaning-making processes aligned with Neimeyer’s theory of reconstructing one’s identity and worldview following significant loss.

These narratives demonstrate that continued bonds are not indicators of unresolved grief but rather essential elements of adaptive grieving. Maintaining symbolic connections helped griever regulate emotions and honor the relational depth of the loss.

Talking to the animal, keeping mementos, or engaging in rituals were common practices that offset the effects of social invalidation.

Participants described altars, photos, letters, tattoos, and conversations with the departed animal as deeply comforting and spiritually grounding. As found in studies by [Hunter \(2018\)](#) and [Mouton \(2024\)](#), these private grief practices were especially valuable when institutional or communal recognition was absent. For many, they served as both coping strategies and meaning-making tools, helping individuals transition from acute grief to long-term emotional integration.

The Restorative Role of Social Recognition

While invalidation was a common experience, participants also described moments of being seen and supported that had profound restorative effects. Even simple gestures such as a condolence card, a kind word, or someone using the animal's name helped rehumanize their grief and affirmed the legitimacy of their sorrow. P031 reflected, "That mere acknowledgment, even a card, validated that I was feeling something and that somebody else cared." These moments of recognition allowed grief to be shared, even briefly, offering emotional grounding and relief from the isolation of disenfranchisement.

More intentional forms of support were also deeply meaningful. P007 shared, "The vet made a blanket with Max's photo on it. She gave us resources and checked in. That support meant a lot." Similarly, P026 recalled, "We had everybody sit in a circle and tell stories. It was kind of like a funeral. It helped." These acts provided comfort, and they signaled that the relationship and the grief were worthy of collective care. Collective care initiatives, such as animal-loss support charities, memorial services, and online remembrance communities, provide a sense of belonging and shared mourning. These communal spaces extend Neimeyer's notion of narrative sharing by translating individual grief into collective validation.

Recognition also played a protective role in the emotional adaptation process. Participants who received support reported feeling more emotionally regulated and less isolated. In contrast, those who faced silence, dismissal, or suggestions to "just get another pet" often experienced intensified pain. Support that was perceived as helpful was rarely complex; it was relational, empathetic, and anchored in presence. These findings align with [Doka's \(2002, 2008\)](#) and [Brown et al.'s \(2023\)](#) work, which show that even small acknowledgments can buffer the psychological toll of disenfranchised grief.

Participants emphasized that peer-based communities, particularly animal loss support groups, were among the most validating spaces. Whether online or in person, these groups allowed for shared storytelling and mirrored understanding. This mutual empathy helped reduce shame and offered a container for meaning-making. These findings reflect [Neimeyer's \(2020\)](#) assertion that narrative sharing is vital for restoring coherence after loss and affirm the significance of group rituals and memorial practices in disenfranchised grief contexts.

Individualized therapy was also noted as impactful when clinicians demonstrated grief literacy and honored the depth of animal loss. Participants reported feeling emotionally safe and more able to process their grief when a professional validated their emotional reality. Conversely, when clinicians minimized or misunderstood the loss, it often resulted in re-traumatization and emotional withdrawal. This underscores the need for grief-informed training within mental health, veterinary, and animal care professions.

Gratitude emerged as a powerful theme within the context of social support. Participants often transitioned from acute sorrow to emotional integration through reflections on the love, lessons, and life shared with the animal. These practices fostered spiritual continuity and a sense of purpose in honoring the bond. Such gratitude-based meaning-making supports Neimeyer's framework and is echoed in recent studies showing that gratitude activates emotion regulation processes and supports resilience (Elfers et al., 2024; Hazlett et al., 2021).

Ultimately, the findings affirm that the most healing forms of support were those that validated the grief, honored the relationship, and created a space for remembrance. These acts, while often small, helped reweave the mourner's emotional story into one of connection, continuity, and meaning, countering the erasure so often experienced in disenfranchised grief.

Discussion

This study explored the lived experiences of disenfranchised grief following the death of a beloved animal, revealing a depth of emotional, cognitive, and relational impact that remains largely underrecognized in grief literature and clinical settings. Drawing from 31 rich participant narratives and grounded in Neimeyer's Meaning Reconstruction theory, this research offers several novel contributions. It extends the understanding of disenfranchised grief by focusing specifically on animal loss, an often overlooked but deeply impactful experience. It highlights how the invalidation of that grief disrupts identity, meaning-making, and socio-emotional integration. It also brings forward the voices of animal care professionals, a group facing layered grief with little institutional acknowledgment. It illustrates how continued bonds, gratitude practices, and small moments of social recognition can serve as powerful mechanisms of healing. These findings not only confirm prior research but also fill critical gaps by illuminating how animal-related grief operates at the intersection of attachment, identity, and social legitimacy.

One of the most salient findings was the psychological toll of disenfranchised grief. Consistent with existing research on grief hierarchies (Doka, 2008; Park & Royal, 2020), participants reported that their grief was often minimized, misunderstood, or dismissed by others. This contributed to emotional suppression, social withdrawal, and mental health strain. The pain participants described stemmed not only from the loss itself but from grieving in a context where their sorrow was unacknowledged. Neimeyer (2020) describes this as a rupture in the meaning-making process, where mourners are unable to construct a coherent, socially supported narrative about their experience. This

study expands that understanding by illustrating how invalidation also undermines identity, particularly among participants whose caregiving roles were central to their self-concept.

Extending this perspective beyond the individual, a family systems lens further reveals how the loss of a companion animal can ripple through relational hierarchies and roles within the home. In more hierarchical or closed family systems, emotional expression may be constrained, resulting in suppressed or displaced grief responses among family members (Barney & Yoshimura, 2020; Thacker & Duran, 2022). Recognizing these systemic patterns allows clinicians to address family-level dynamics that may reinforce disenfranchisement or impede mutual support.

The findings also underscore that continued bonds and meaning-making are vital to adaptive grief. Participants described personal rituals, symbolic acts, and reflective gratitude practices that helped them honor their animals and reconstruct meaning in the absence of external support. These practices served both emotional and cognitive functions, helping to regulate grief responses and sustain a sense of connection. This aligns with Neimeyer's (2016, 2020) assertion that storytelling, ritual, and symbolic continuity are essential components of healthy grieving. The data further support critiques of linear, stage-based models by highlighting more dynamic and identity-based mourning processes.

This study also aligns with key areas of Omega's scholarly focus, particularly the public health, cultural, and existential dimensions of grief. First, the findings have meaningful public health implications, especially for therapist education, grief support programs, and veterinary or animal care settings. Participants emphasized the need for professionals to be trained in grief validation and ritual-sensitive interventions to avoid compounding disenfranchisement. Beyond therapeutic and veterinary settings, the findings have broader implications for workplace environments. When grief is unrecognized or unsupported, especially after the death of a beloved animal, individuals may experience reduced productivity, increased absenteeism, and emotional disengagement. This can lead to lower morale and affect team cohesion, particularly in emotionally demanding fields such as animal care, healthcare, or education. As such, disenfranchised grief is not just a private emotional concern; it can influence organizational outcomes and public health more broadly, underscoring the need for compassionate policies and training within professional settings.

Second, this study reinforces how grief following animal loss is shaped by broader cultural narratives that devalue emotional expression and reflect discomfort with death itself, particularly when the loss falls outside normative hierarchies. Finally, the findings underscore the existential disruption caused by unacknowledged grief. The disruption of identity, meaning, and connection described by participants reflects the type of psychologically and spiritually transformative experience central to Omega's mission.

Another key finding was the restorative role of social recognition. Participants emphasized that even small gestures, such as a condolence message or shared memory, helped affirm their emotional reality. These moments helped rehumanize their grief and buffer the effects of disenfranchisement. This supports prior work by Brown et al.

(2023) and Marton et al. (2020), showing that relational presence and acknowledgment can significantly mitigate grief-related distress. These findings extend such conclusions to the context of animal loss, demonstrating that validation need not be elaborate, only sincere.

Several novel contributions emerge from this study. First, it highlights the layered grief experienced by animal care professionals, who encounter occupational exposure to death, euthanasia, and cumulative loss with limited institutional support. This form of professional disenfranchisement has received limited attention and merits further research. Beyond a professional setting, however, the concept of layered grief emerged across both professional and personal contexts. While animal care professionals experienced cumulative loss through occupational exposure, at-home caregivers described intersecting grief resulting from repeated experiences of companion-animal loss or from prior unresolved losses. Thus, layered grief operates across contexts, amplifying emotional fatigue and underscoring the need for tailored support. Second, the study emphasizes the protective role of gratitude. Participants who engaged in gratitude-based reflection reported greater socio-emotional integration and post-loss growth. This complements emerging research in neuroscience and psychology linking gratitude to emotion regulation and resilience (Elfers et al., 2024; Hazlett et al., 2021).

Ultimately, this study amplifies the voices of griever whose pain is often unseen. It calls on psychologists, counselors, and veterinary professionals to recognize that grief for an animal can rupture identity, erode psychological well-being, and, when validated, become a powerful site for healing and transformation. Recognizing animal-related grief affirms the mourner's emotional reality while advancing ethical standards, improving clinical outcomes, and deepening our understanding of grief within cultural and existential contexts.

While Meaning Reconstruction theory provided the primary interpretive framework, parallels can be drawn with the Dual Process Model of coping with bereavement (Stroebe & Schut, 2016). Both emphasize oscillation between loss-oriented and restoration-oriented processes. Participants' narratives reflected this movement, shifting between deep mourning and gratitude-based reengagement with life. Integrating these perspectives may enhance the understanding of adaptive coping following disenfranchised grief (Cordaro, 2012; Stroebe & Schut, 2016).

Implications for Practice

These findings offer critical insights for psychologists, counselors, educators, veterinarians, grief support providers, and organizational leaders. First, practitioners must broaden their conceptualization of grief to include non-human losses, particularly when those losses are central to identity, emotional regulation, or psychological safety. Second, even brief acknowledgments of grief, whether clinical, interpersonal, or institutional, can profoundly affirm the mourner's experience and reduce emotional isolation.

Mental health professionals should consider integrating grief-informed practices that incorporate storytelling, ritual, and symbolic continuity, especially when supporting

clients navigating marginalized or disenfranchised loss. Veterinary professionals and animal care institutions would benefit from training in grief literacy and trauma-informed approaches to better support both clients and staff during end-of-life transitions.

Additionally, employers across industries may consider adopting more inclusive bereavement policies that recognize the emotional impact of disenfranchised grief. Expanding leave policies to acknowledge losses that fall outside conventional hierarchies, including the death of an animal, may help reduce absenteeism, improve morale, and support workplace well-being. Training managers in grief sensitivity and offering flexible supports can foster organizational cultures that validate emotional complexity and promote psychological safety.

Beyond organizational implications, cultural norms also shape how grief is expressed and validated. The experience of animal loss and its acknowledgment vary across cultural frameworks. In collectivist cultures, grief is often shared communally, while in more individualistic societies, emotional expression is frequently privatized (Silverman et al., 2021). Moreover, social hierarchies influence which losses are legitimized or silenced. In this study's primarily Western sample, participants' experiences reflected a cultural discomfort with non-human death and emotional vulnerability. Cross-cultural studies (e.g., Zhou et al., 2022) suggest that communal acknowledgment may buffer distress, underscoring the importance of situating animal-related grief within a cultural context.

Conclusion

This study affirms that animal loss is not a peripheral concern, but a profoundly significant human experience, one that intersects with identity, attachment, and psychological well-being. By elevating the voices of those experiencing disenfranchised grief, this study contributes to a more inclusive and responsive understanding of bereavement in contemporary psychology. The emotional depth, narrative richness, and meaning-making processes shared by participants underscore the need for expanded research, professional training, and public dialogue in this area. These results add to a growing body of literature advocating for the inclusion of non-human relationships within grief frameworks.

Given the frequency and intensity with which people bond with animals, dominant grief paradigms must evolve to reflect more inclusive and relational understandings of loss. This includes validating grief that falls outside traditional hierarchies, especially when such losses profoundly impact identity and emotional well-being. Doing so may reduce stigma, improve access to support, and foster more compassionate societal and professional responses.

These findings may also be transferable to other disenfranchised grief contexts, such as losses involving friends, ex-partners, or stigmatized relationships where grief is often invalidated or unsupported. Like those losses, animal loss frequently lacks ritual, communal acknowledgment, or formalized space for mourning. Thus, the study's insights may inform broader grief education and intervention models, advocating for

more expansive definitions of what constitutes valid grief and who is permitted to grieve. Ultimately, this work contributes to a deeper understanding of relational loss and challenges cultural norms about whose grief deserves recognition.

Limitations

While the study included participants across various ages and professions, the sample comprised individuals who voluntarily reflected on their grief, which may indicate a self-selection bias toward more intense or enduring experiences. Cultural differences in grief expression were not fully explored, and the English-speaking sample may limit generalizability to non-Western populations. However, the emotional patterns of attachment, disruption, and the search for meaning observed here are broadly consistent with cross-cultural grief literature.

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Author Biography

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